

STAGE EIGHT • SOFT SKILLS

FIRSTS

Soft Skills

SESSION 1

Communication & Listening

8 FIRSTS

Active Listening Exercise

- Most people listen to reply, not understand
- Genuine understanding builds far stronger trust
- The foundation for this whole section

Assertive Communication Practice

- Not passive, not aggressive — the middle path
- A practiced skill, not a personality trait
- Watch for over-apologizing before the actual ask

Communication Style Awareness

- Your default style, only partially seen by you
- Self-perception $\neq$ actual impact
- Check it against how others really experience you

Listening Without Interrupting

- Even well-meant interruptions damage trust
- Genuinely harder than it sounds
- Track it — most people underestimate their own habit

Body Language Awareness

- Non-verbal cues often carry more than words
- Awareness, not constant self-monitoring
- Overcorrecting has its own cost

Inclusive Communication Practice

- Groups default to the loudest voices
- Silence isn't agreement — it's often unasked
- A concrete, practicable habit, not just a value

Empathetic Response Exercise

- The instinct: jump straight to solutions
- What's often needed first: feeling understood
- Acknowledge before you advise

Listening for Understanding

- Summarizing forces genuine processing
- Closes the loop on this whole section
- Feels slow under pressure — worth it anyway

SESSION 2

Emotional Intelligence & Self-Awareness

8 FIRSTS

Empathy Reflection

- Empathy isn't always automatic mid-disagreement
- Reflect after, to build the habit for next time
- The foundation for this whole section

Emotional Awareness Reflection

- Unnoticed patterns repeat themselves
- Observe with curiosity, not judgment
- Sets up Emotional Regulation later in this section

Patience Challenge

- Trainable, not a fixed trait
- Small moments build capacity for big ones
- A real commitment, not just a reflection

Perspective-Taking Exercise

- Most disagreements look reasonable from both sides
- Real test: can you state their view fairly?
- Not the same as secretly still thinking you're right

Emotional Intelligence Practice

- You can't manage what you can't accurately name
- “Fine” and “stressed” are starting points, not endpoints
- Build genuinely specific vocabulary

Emotional Regulation Drill

- A skill built by practice, not innate
- Practice now, at low stakes
- Don't wait for the real crisis to try it first

Cultural Awareness Reflection

- Genuine awareness, not just tolerance
- An ongoing practice, not a checkbox
- Watch for overgeneralizing from one interaction

Personal Values Statement

- Guides decisions consistently, not by mood
- Closes the section — self-awareness into a standard
- Test: does it match how you've actually behaved?

SESSION 3

Feedback & Conflict Resolution

8 FIRSTS

Feedback Given

- Discomfort leads most people to avoid it entirely
- Specificity matters more than diplomacy
- The foundation for this whole section

Feedback Received Gracefully

- Your reaction shapes future honesty from others
- Defensiveness discourages people from being honest again
- Pairs directly with Feedback Given

Conflict Resolution Practice

- Avoided conflict resurfaces worse later
- A distinct, learnable skill, not a trait
- Genuinely uncomfortable — that's normal

Team Conflict Debrief

- Without debrief, teams repeat the same patterns
- Specific, actionable takeaways, not just venting
- Extends individual conflict skill to the team level

Conflict Mediation Role Played

- Distinct from resolving your own conflicts
- Genuine neutrality, even subtly, is the hard part
- Valuable for team dynamics and future leadership

Team Feedback Session Facilitated

- Unstructured sessions go vague or too personal
- Structure keeps it genuinely productive
- Combines L5, L6, and L35's skills together

Negotiation Exercise

- Relevant far beyond salary discussions
- Collaborative beats adversarial
- Assertiveness (L4) applied to a structured context

Boundary Setting Exercise

- No boundaries → overcommitment, resentment
- Stated well, boundaries build credibility
- Closes the section: protecting your real capacity

SESSION 4

Teamwork & Collaboration

9 FIRSTS

Collaboration Challenge Completed

- Easy collaboration doesn't build much skill
- Real friction is where the growth happens
- The foundation for this whole section

Team Role Assumed

- Deliberate roles beat default comfort
- A conscious choice, not falling into place
- Sets up Team Role Rotation later in this section

Collaborative Brainstorm

- Unstructured brainstorming underperforms
- Separate generation from evaluation, explicitly
- Judgment too early suppresses real ideas

Problem-Solving Discussion

- Groups can beat any one individual — with structure
- Don't converge on the first, loudest idea
- Extends L32's structure into applied problem-solving

Group Decision Facilitated

- No buy-in, decisions unravel later
- Explicitly check for unaddressed concerns
- Silence $\neq$ agreement

Team Role Rotation Experience

- Comfort limits growth
- Unfamiliar roles reveal hidden strengths
- Watch for reverting under pressure

Remote/Virtual Work Adaptation

- Informal cues are lost remotely
- Text often reads harsher than intended
- More deliberate communication compensates

Peer Recognition Shared

- Genuine contributions go unnoticed by default
- Specific beats generic (“great job everyone”)
- Reinforces the behaviors worth repeating

Decision-Making Log

- Honest reasoning fades once the outcome is known
- Log the rationale at the time, not after
- Closes the section: a genuine learning record

SESSION 5

Networking & Public Speaking

9 FIRSTS

Public Speaking Confidence Drill

- Content mastery $\neq$ audience comfort
- Real people build real comfort
- The foundation for this whole section

Presentation to Mixed Audience

- One style rarely lands for a whole mixed room
- Adapt tone and language within one presentation
- Don't lose your core message while adapting

Networking Conversation

- Transactional networking rarely builds real ties
- Genuine curiosity produces durable connections
- Not about what you can get from it

Peer Mentoring Session

- Distinct skill from being mentored
- Guide toward understanding, don't just do it for them
- Teaching deepens your own grasp too

Mentor Interaction

- Value depends on how well you engage
- Specific questions beat passive listening
- The flip side of being a good peer mentor

Networking Follow-Up Practice

- Value is lost in the failure to follow up
- Only reaching out when you need something reads badly
- Proactive follow-up sustains the relationship

Networking Event Reflection

- Without reflection, your approach stays static
- Skipping it because the event's over is the trap
- Closes the loop on L12 and L22

Presentation Handling Q&A

- Unscripted moments reveal real understanding
- A brief pause beats a rushed, rambling answer
- A distinct skill from prepared delivery

Motivational Speech Practice

- Distinct from informational presenting
- Genuine story beats generic inspiration
- Closes the section: confidence + audience + authenticity

SESSION 6

Growth Mindset & Resilience

8 FIRSTS

Adaptability Exercise

- Unexpected change is inevitable
- A trainable skill, not a fixed trait
- The foundation for this whole section

Critical Thinking Exercise

- Snap judgments are often wrong
- Treat first impressions as hypotheses, not fact
- Confidence in a judgment $\neq$ its accuracy

Leadership Reflection

- Leadership style forms unconsciously through habit
- The best lessons hide in moments that went poorly
- Don't reflect only on your wins

Stress Management Technique

- Prevents burnout, supports better decisions
- No universal technique — experiment for yourself
- Connects to Emotional Regulation from Session 2

Gratitude Practice

- Measurably improves mood and outlook
- Specificity beats generic, repetitive entries
- Especially useful during real stress

Resilience Exercise

- Trainable, not fixed
- Neither suppress it nor dwell on it indefinitely
- Work toward one concrete next step

Time Management Reflection

- Generic advice ignores real individual variation
- Your own patterns beat someone else's system
- Self-reflection over borrowed productivity hacks

Reflection on Soft Skill Growth

- The whole stage's pattern, not just one moment
- Closes out Stage Eight entirely
- Honesty about hard areas matters most here

Stage Eight, Complete

One soft skill genuinely grown, named with a real example.